central government. In any case, he mollifyingly replied, 'The border conflict with India – this is only a marginal border issue, not a clash between the two governments.'[5]

By 1960, India had received more Soviet aid than China. In March 1961, Delhi bought eight Antonov-12 military transport airplanes. In May 1962, five months before the war with China, news surfaced of India's likely purchase of the MiG-21 fighter, an aircraft Moscow had refused to sell to China. Under pressure from the US and the UK over the purchase of the MiGs, Nehru confided to a senior British diplomat that the military value of the fighters was less important than the sale's negative impact on Sino-Soviet relations.[6] In August 1962, just weeks before the outbreak of war, India signed the MiG deal as also an agreement for more Antonov airplanes. After the war, between 1964 and 1968, India bought tanks (in the hundreds), combat aircraft (primarily, four MiG squadrons), and artillery.[7]

When the war of words between Delhi and Beijing worsened further, Moscow found itself embroiled in the nail-biting Cuban missile crisis with Washington. As late as 18 October, two days before the Chinese attack on India, it urged both India and China to avoid violence. When war broke out, the Soviets abruptly sided with China in an effort to rally the socialist world against the US, but as soon as the crisis with Washington ended, Moscow turned critical of Beijing again. The Soviet newspaper *Pravda* sniffed that 'Aspirations for war is foreign to the nature of a socialist state'.[8] Not surprisingly, Sino-Soviet relations worsened, despite the ouster of Mao's bugbear, Khrushchev, in 1964. When Soviet tanks rolled into Czechoslovakia in 1968 to put down an anti-communist rebellion, Beijing was harshly critical of Moscow – its stand paralleling that of the West.

The US backs India against China

From the 1940s, despite its differences with the US, India had received a growing amount of American aid. Initially, these were food shipments. Later, the aid was more broadly developmental. The amounts grew